Gadadhara Pandita

Гададхара Пандит · @gadadhara-pandita

The Potency of the Devotee

Gadadhara Pandita Gosvami is one of the five forms in which the Lord appeared in Gaura-lila. Sri Gauranga, Nityananda, Advaita, Gadadhara and Srivasa make up the Pancha-tattva: in essence They are not different, and They divided only to relish the various tastes of devotional service. In this row Gadadhara is the energy, the shakti, of the devotee. So too teaches the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika”: “And ‘the potency of the devotee’ is the foremost of brahmanas, Sri Gadadhara Pandita” (GGD 11). Krishnadasa Kaviraja defines the place of each in the Pancha-tattva:

“The first three truths (Sri Chaitanya, Nityananda Prabhu and Advaita Acharya) are the highest object of worship for all living beings. The fourth truth (Gadadhara Prabhu) eternally worships and serves Them. <…> No one can count all the pure devotees of Krishna, headed by Srivasa Pandita. And all of them represent the very truth of bhakti. <…> And the manifestations of the divine energies, represented by Gadadhara Pandita, are considered the intimate associates of the Supreme Lord.” (CC, Adi 7.15–17)

Mahaprabhu is one; the two Prabhus, Nityananda and Advaita, serve Him, and these three are worthy of worship; Srivasa and the others are the devotees who worship; and Gadadhara Pandita and those like him are embodiments of the Lord's energies, His most confidential associates. All the mahajanas of the past unanimously recognized Gadadhara as one of the Pancha-tattva. At the very beginning of the “Charitamrita” the author bows down to him:

“With reverence I bow down thousands of times to the internal personal energies of the Lord. Gadadhara Pandita is the manifestation of one of His most confidential Shaktis.” (CC, Adi 1.41)

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati explains: Gadadhara Pandita is the first among those closest to Sri Chaitanya, the source of all shakti-tattva, and therefore he is equally present in the lilas of Navadvipa and in the lilas of Nilachala. When Gaura shows His oneness with Narayana, His shaktis are His consorts Lakshmipriya and Vishnupriya; when He shows His oneness with Krishna, His shakti is Gadadhara. Together with Svarupa Damodara and Ramananda Raya, Gadadhara is a shakti of madhura-rasa: they nourish and sustain the vipralambha, the separation, that Gaurasundara relishes.

The “Charitamrita” too speaks of this:

“Sri Chaitanya relished the feelings of parental love with Paramananda Puri, friendship with Ramananda Raya, service with Govinda and others, and also the rasa of conjugal love with Gadadhara, Jagadananda and Svarupa Damodara. These four rasas gave Him indescribable joy, and for this He felt Himself in unrepayable debt to these devotees.” (CC, Madhya 2.78)

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta explains: Gadadhara, Jagadananda and Svarupa served the Lord in the principal rasa — madhura-rasa, and the Lord, accepting their worship, company and service, was indebted to these devotees.

Sri Chaitanya is glorified as “the life of Nityananda and Gadadhara”:

“Glory to Him, the very life of Nityananda and Gadadhara! Glory to Him, the treasure of the hearts of Advaita and Srivasa!” (CB, Madhya 9.3)

Bhaktisiddhanta also unfolds this double title. Pure devotees who wish to worship Radha-Govinda in madhura-rasa take shelter of Gadadhara, and they are considered Gauranga's confidential devotees; those not so inclined take shelter of Nityananda. Therefore some call the Lord “the life of Nityananda,” and others “the life of Gadadhara.” Some of Mahaprabhu's associates — Narahari Sarakara, for example

— themselves became followers of Gadadhara: they knew that he was dearest of all to the Lord, and therefore sought to serve him.

He has several names. He is called “Gaura-shakti,” “Pandita Gosvami” (in Bengali, Pandita-gosani), “Gadadhara Deva,” and, affectionately, Gadai. And because of him the Lord is called “Gadadhara-prananatha,” “the Lord of Gadadhara's life,” and “Gadai-Gauranga,” “the Gauranga who belongs to Gadadhara”; these names were current already in the time of Krishnadasa Kaviraja, and he himself cites them in the “Charitamrita” (Antya 7.159–160; on this, see below).

Family and Birth

Gadadhara was born in the village of Beleti in the district of Chittagong (now in Bangladesh)[1] in the year 1408 of the Shaka era (1486), on the new moon of the month of Vaishakha; this day, the amavasya of Vaishakha, is honored as the day of his appearance. Whether he was the same age as the Lord or a year younger, the biographies say differently[2]. His father, Madhava Mishra, was a Varendra brahmana of the Kashyapa gotra; his mother's name was Ratnavati Devi, and his younger brother's, Vaninatha.

Chittagong gave Gaura-lila many associates: Mukunda Datta and Vasudeva Datta also came from there, and Madhava Mishra was a close friend of Pundarika Vidyanidhi — his son's future guru. The family lived in Beleti until Gadadhara was twelve years old, and then moved to Navadvipa. Their house stood in Mayapur, next door to the house of Jagannatha Mishra; Ratnavati revered Shachi Devi as an elder sister, and the two were almost never apart.

Childhood beside Nimai

So from childhood Gadadhara became Nimai's inseparable companion. Gaurahari often played with him, they went together to the village school, and Gadadhara loved Him so much that he could not part from Him for a moment. From his earliest years he was the Lord's closest devotee and His friend.

In temperament they were unlike. Gadadhara grew up serious and restrained, calm, and fond of solitude; from a tender age he was indifferent to worldly pleasures, strict and detached in daily life, and so — a brahmachari — he remained all his life. Nimai, in those years, seemed restless and wilful. At school He plagued Gadadhara with tricky questions that threw him into confusion; this hindered his studies, and Gadadhara tried to keep his distance from Him — yet he could not bear separation either. Once Nimai told him: “Gadadhara! Soon I shall become such a Vaishnava that Brahma and Shiva will come to bow down to Me.”

Later, when Nimai had become the foremost scholar of Navadvipa, no one dared to argue with Him: He would first refute any thesis and then defend it Himself. Mukunda, Srivasa and the other devotees avoided these debates. Once Nimai asked Gadadhara what liberation is. He answered according to nyaya: the final and complete cessation of suffering (atyantika-duhkha-nivritti). Nimai showed that this definition was insufficient, and the devotees, listening, thought how good it would be if such a scholar became a devotee.

In those same years Ishvara Puri came to Navadvipa and stayed for several months in the house of Gopinatha Acharya (CB, Adi 11.96)[3]. He grew fond of Gadadhara: he saw in the youth an innate detachment, present since childhood, he saw streams of tears of love for Krishna — and with affection he began to teach him his book “Sri Krishna-lilamrita,” straight from the manuscript. As the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (12.2205–2207) reports, it was in the house of Gopinatha Acharya that Puri wrote this book. Vrindavana Dasa relates:

“Ishvara Puri began to teach Gadadhara Pandita from his book ‘Sri Krishna-lilamrita.’” (CB, Adi 11.100)

Every day, while Puri was teaching Gadadhara, Nimai would come and bow to Puri; once Puri asked Him to correct the mistakes in the book, and Nimai replied that Krishna accepts any glorification composed by His devotee, even an imperfect one (CB, Adi 11.105–110).

Once Gauranga took Gadadhara with Him to the house of Advaita Acharya — to see what He was doing. Advaita was preparing for the puja of His household Deity and loudly singing the name of Hari; hearing this, Gauranga fell unconscious before Him, and Advaita worshipped His feet with the articles of puja and began to sing a hymn to Govinda. Gadadhara bit his tongue in astonishment and objected: it is not fitting for a venerable elder to worship the feet of a boy. Advaita smiled: “Gadadhara, in a few days you will know who this boy is.” And Gadadhara began to wonder: could Gauranga Himself be the One for whose sake Advaita had performed all His worship?

The Awakening of Love

When the Lord returned from Gaya, the first to see His transformations of love was Shriman Pandita; he told the devotees of them, and the Lord appointed a meeting with them in the house of Shuklambara Brahmachari. Hearing of this from Shriman, Gadadhara hurried after him and hid in the house: the Lord would surely speak of Krishna — and he wanted to listen, if only in secret. The Lord spoke on the veranda, while Gadadhara sat inside. When the Lord, crying “Where is Krishna?”, fell to the ground, Gadadhara in the next room also lost consciousness (CB, Madhya 1.86–88)[4]. Coming to Himself, the Lord asked who was hiding there, and Shuklambara replied: “It is Your Gadadhara” (1.96). Vrindavana Dasa continues:

“Gadadhara lowered his head and wept. Seeing this, Vishvambhara felt deep satisfaction. He said: ‘O Gadadhara, you are very fortunate. From your very childhood you have been endowed with strong faith in Krishna. But I have wasted My life on meaningless pursuits. Recently I found a priceless treasure, but by misfortune I have lost it.’” (CB, Madhya 1.97–99)

The Lord embraced him. Witnesses of His transformations in the house of Shuklambara were Gadadhara, Sadashiva, Murari, Srivasa, Shriman and others. From that time it became hard for Gadadhara to part from the Lord even for an hour; seeing His tears of love, he too would weep.

Once Gadadhara brought the Lord betel. The Lord, tormented by separation from Krishna, turned to him with a question:

“Seeing Gadadhara, Vishvambhara asked: ‘Where is that dark-complexioned Krishna in yellow garments?’ <…> In great agitation Gadadhara Mahashaya answered: ‘Krishna always dwells in Your heart.’ But as soon as Mahaprabhu heard that Krishna was in His heart, He began to tear at His chest with His nails. Gadadhara at once seized Vishvambhara by the hands and calmed Him, speaking many consoling words. Gadadhara said: ‘Be patient, Krishna will come now.’ Mother Shachi saw this. Mother Shachi was very pleased with Gadadhara. She thought: ‘I have never met such a clever youth before. I cannot approach my son out of fear. Yet this youth was able to calm Him so skilfully.’” (CB, Madhya 2.203, 205–210)

“Let go of My hands!” the Lord pleaded. “If I do not see Krishna, I cannot live.” Shachi asked Gadadhara always to stay by Nimai, and from then on he calmed the Lord whenever the waves of love overwhelmed Him.

In the Navadvipa-lila Gadadhara became the Lord's chief helper. Those who in Vrindavana are Radha and Krishna are here, on the banks of the Ganga, Gaura and Gadadhara; and the cowherd girls and boys of Vrindavana take part in this lila as the performers of kirtana. Once the Lord, strolling by the Ganga, sat down in a grove and became absorbed in remembering the pastimes of Vrindavana. Mukunda began to sing of purva-raga — the first awakening of love; Gadadhara gathered flowers in the forest and

placed a garland on the Lord, as Radha adorned Krishna, and some began to sing, some to dance. Then Gauranga seated Gadadhara beside Him on a raised place at the foot of a tree. Advaita performed arati to Them both, Nityananda sat on the left, Srivasa decorated Them with flowers, Narahari fanned Them with a chamara, Shuklambara offered sandalwood paste, Murari sang Their glories, and Madhava, Vasudeva, Purushottama, Vijaya, Mukunda and others sang in various ragas.

Gadadhara was with the Lord in all His pastimes: at the night kirtanas in the houses of Srivasa and Chandrashekhara (CB, Madhya 8.111–112), in the water pastimes after the deliverance of Jagai and Madhai, at the mahaprakasha in Srivasa's courtyard, in the procession to the Kazi, and later at the sannyasa; in Puri — at the cleaning of the Gundicha temple, at the bathing in Narendra lake, and in many other pastimes. At one of the kirtanas behind closed doors, still before the procession to the Kazi, Nityananda and Gadadhara whirled about holding hands, while Advaita, like a lion, rushed about the room (CB, Madhya 23.30)[5]. When the Vaishnavas spoke of Nityananda and Gauranga — two Lords who honor each other — and Srivasa compared Them to Madhava and Shankara, Gadadhara took it up: “Well said; it is like the story of Rama and Lakshmana.”

A special place among these pastimes belongs to the drama in the house of Chandrashekhara Acharya. The Lord Himself assigned the roles: Haridasa was the village watchman, Srivasa was Narada, He Himself was Rukmini, and Gadadhara too was Rukmini, with Brahmananda as her old friend Suprabha (CB, Madhya 18.9). In the second prahara of the evening Gadadhara came out together with Brahmananda, dressed as a maiden of Vraja, his heart overflowing with love, and began to dance:

“Hearing Advaita's words, Gadadhara was very satisfied. Then he began to dance under the influence of ecstatic love. Gadadhara danced wonderfully in the garments of Rama, the goddess of fortune, and his ‘companion’ sang songs befitting the occasion. <…> At that moment Gadadhara was like the Ganga personified. In truth, he is a manifestation of Krishna's internal energy. Lord Chaitanya said again and again: ‘In Vaikuntha Gadadhara is My wife.’” (CB, Madhya 18.111–112, 115–116)

Then the Lord appeared as the original energy, adya-shakti, the Mother of the universe[6].

That Gaura and Gadadhara are inseparable is told also by the “Navadvipa-dhama-mahatmya”: the pious king Suvarna Sena of Suvarna-vihara in Godrumadvipa, by the mercy of Narada, saw in a dream Gaura and Gadadhara with all Their associates, and on waking grieved that the vision was gone.

Pundarika Vidyanidhi

In those days the Lord would weep and call: “Pundarika, My father!” — but none of the devotees knew Pundarika. He had in fact come to Navadvipa, but he went unrecognized: he hid his deep devotion and carried himself like a pampered lover of pleasure. Only Mukunda and Vasudeva Datta, his countrymen, knew him. Gadadhara, though he came from the same parts, did not know him — according to one biography, only in appearance, for the sake of the lila.

Gadadhara was especially attached to Mukunda, and Mukunda loved him dearly: whenever a sadhu or sannyasi came to Navadvipa, Mukunda would call Gadadhara and they would go to him together. And now Mukunda said[7] that he would introduce him to an extraordinary Vaishnava, not of this world — “and as a reward, remember me as your servant.” Gadadhara gladly went at once. Mukunda presented him: “This is Gadadhara. From childhood he has been indifferent to the world; in worldly terms he is the son of the brahmana Madhava Mishra; from an early age he has kept to renunciation and is dear to all the Vaishnavas; he has come because he heard your name.” Vidyanidhi was overjoyed and spoke with him warmly[8].

But what Gadadhara saw troubled him. Pundarika sat like a prince: a high bed, silk sheets whiter than milk foam, soft pillows, a canopy, costly clothes, incense and perfumes, five or seven little jars, pan in a

brass box, a hookah; two servants fanned him with peacock-feather fans; on his forehead were the urdhva-pundra and a red dot of abir, his hair was well groomed, and before him stood an ornate palanquin. “If he is a Vaishnava,” Gadadhara thought, “why does he look so much like a worldly man?” — and he was disappointed.

Mukunda understood his doubt and wished to reveal who Pundarika really was. He sweetly sang a verse of the “Bhagavatam” about Putana — how Krishna granted the position of a mother even to the demoness who came to poison Him[9]. With a cry of “Ha Krishna!” Pundarika fell unconscious. He wept, “Krishna! Krishna!” — his tears flowed like the descending Ganga, he rolled on the floor, overturned the hookah, tore his clothes; all eight sattvika-bhavas appeared on him, without the slightest artifice. Gadadhara was astounded. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, commenting on this story, warns: a Vaishnava cannot be recognized by his outward appearance; devotees of Krishna sometimes hide themselves in the guise of worldly men, and whoever judges by dress loses faith in the Vaishnava-guru. So Gadadhara's doubt too is no flaw in an eternal associate, but a part of the lila through which the Lord gives this lesson.

Remorse seized Gadadhara: “I took a mahabhagavata for an ordinary lover of pleasure and offended him. I will take mantra from him — and be forgiven; I see no other way”[10]. He opened his heart to Mukunda, and Mukunda, waiting until Vidyanidhi came to himself two praharas later, conveyed it: “Gadadhara had a flaw in his thoughts; in atonement he wishes to receive mantra from you.” Pundarika was happy: “The Lord has brought me together with a great jewel: such a disciple is obtained only after many, many births. On the coming shukla-dvadashi, at the most auspicious hour, Gadadhara will receive diksha.”

Gadadhara and Mukunda came to the Lord, told Him of Vidyanidhi's arrival (and it was then that Pundarika met the Lord), and Gadadhara said that he had decided to take initiation from him. The Lord was delighted: “Quickly, quickly!” On the appointed auspicious day Gadadhara received mantra from Pundarika Vidyanidhi. Thus two persons dear to Krishna Chaitanya became for each other a worthy guru and a worthy disciple; Gadadhara enacted the lila of choosing his guru — and through Pundarika, a disciple of Madhavendra Puri, entered his line. In Krishna-lila Pundarika is Vrishabhanu, the father of Radha, and Gadadhara is Radha Herself; that is why the Lord, in the mood of Radha, called Pundarika “father,” and between guru and disciple the love of their former kinship was revealed.

Many years later, in Puri, this bond of guru and disciple was revealed once more:

“Once Sri Gadadhara Pandita asked Sri Chaitanya about the initiation into mantra that he had received. ‘I passed my ishta-mantra on to someone, and now I do not feel its power when I chant. Please grant me this mantra again, and then my mind will find joy.’ <…> The Lord said: ‘You already have a spiritual master, so be careful. You should not commit an offense. What to speak of a mantra — I can give you even My life. But it would be improper to give you mantra while your spiritual master is alive.’ Gadadhara replied: ‘But he is not here now, and You can do it on his behalf.’ Then Lord Chaitanya said: ‘By the will of Providence your spiritual master, Pundarika Vidyanidhi, will soon come here, and you will be able to meet him.’ <…> ‘You will meet him in ten days, for he will come straight to Me.’” (CB, Antya 10.22–28, 30)

And so it happened. When Vidyanidhi came, the Lord exclaimed in rapture, “Father has come!” — and Gadadhara went to his guru and asked him to give him the ishta-mantra again, and he lovingly gave it.

“Thus Gadadhara Pandita had the opportunity to receive mantra again from Premanidhi. What more can be said of Premanidhi's glory? The power of his divine love can be understood simply from the fact that he had such a disciple as Gadadhara Pandita.” (CB, Antya 10.79–80)

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta explains: mantra is sound that frees the mind from the pull toward enjoyment; if it is disclosed to a faithless person, its action in the heart weakens, and then it must be heard again from

one's own guru, not from anyone else. But Gadadhara is an eternal associate of the Lord; no taint could be in him; his words “I do not feel its power” are his humility, a lesson for future gurus and disciples. The “Anubhashya” cites this example too, in speaking of the boy Puri Dasa (CC, Antya 16): a mantra received from the guru is not disclosed to others, or else it loses its power.

The Lord's Sannyasa and the Road to Puri

Govinda Ghosha in his song tells how Gadadhara, hearing that the Lord would leave Navadvipa, ran to Mukunda: “Mukunda, my life! Did I really hear it rightly today? I speak — and die; the words will not leave my lips: Gauranga is leaving Navadvipa… I ran to you without saying anything more to Him; do what you can — as for us, I think we shall not live.” And Mukunda, looking into his face, wept.

Gadadhara was beside the Lord on His last night at home in Navadvipa as well: according to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Madhya 28.43–48), he and Haridasa slept near Him, and before dawn, waking, he said: “I will go with You”; he was present at the sannyasa itself too. When the Lord, having accepted sannyasa, set out from Shantipura for Puri, Gadadhara Pandita was among the few who went with Him — together with Nityananda, Jagadananda and Mukunda Datta[11]. So, when the Nadiya-lila came to its close and the Lord settled in Puri, Gadadhara followed Him and stayed there as well. In the “Charitamrita” he is named first among those who lived with the Lord in Puri:

“Gadadhara Pandita, Vakreshvara, Damodara, Shankara and Haridasa Thakura remained to live with the Lord in Puri.” (CC, Madhya 1.252)

Tota-Gopinatha

In Puri Gadadhara manifested the lila of kshetra-sannyasa — he lived having vowed never to leave the holy land of Purushottama, and Vakreshvara and other associates lived with him in Nilachala. Mahaprabhu entrusted him with the service of the Deity of Gopinatha and told him to live in Yameshvara-tota, a garden by the sea, near the temple of Shiva Yameshvara; after this garden (tota) the Deity is called Tota-Gopinatha. The Lord constantly came to him and became absorbed with him in talks about Krishna. In the hot month of Jyeshtha He stayed with Gadadhara in Yameshvara-tota and from there called Sanatana Gosvami to Him at midday — and Sanatana came across the burning sand. As Abhirama manifested the service of Gopinatha in Khanakula, and Madhu Pandita in Vrindavana, so Gadadhara Pandita manifested in Purushottama-dhama the service of Gopinatha together with the daughter of Vrishabhanu and Ananga-manjari (Jahnava); a song sings of it: “The Lord of Gadadhara's life, the Lord of Jahnava's life — Sri Gopinatha.”

When Nityananda came to Puri and arrived at the Tota, Gadadhara, learning of it, broke off his reading of the “Bhagavatam” and went out to meet Him; Nityananda had brought fine rice from Gauda for Gopinatha, Gadadhara cooked it, and Mahaprabhu too came to the prasada of Gopinatha — the three ate together, and the devotees snatched up the remnants of the meal of Nitai-Gaura-Gadadhara.

Gadadhara's chief service in Puri was the reading of the “Bhagavatam.” By the Lord's order he preached the “Bhagavata” every day on the shore of Narendra lake, and at the Tota he expounded it, sinking into trance — he loved best of all the stories of Prahlada and Dhruva. His explanations were like an ocean of nectar. Gaurasundara would sit down to listen, and at his reading all eight sattvika-bhavas appeared in Him — just as at the kirtana of Svarupa Damodara: the master of the “Bhagavata” was Gadadhara, the master of kirtana was Svarupa. Vakreshvara, together with the Lord, Advaita and others, would go to Tota-Gopinatha to hear his discourses. Hence the lesson: the “Bhagavata”-book must be heard from the “bhagavata”-devotee. Centuries later Bhaktivinoda Thakura likewise heard the “Bhagavata” from Gopinatha Pandita. Vrindavana Dasa calls Gadadhara the preacher of the “Bhagavata,” boundlessly dear to Gaura and Nityananda and non-different from Them; and in the lila of Mahaprabhu, Who is Himself

the embodiment of separation (vipralambha-vigraha), Gadadhara nourishes and sustains this rasa of separation and helps Him in preaching kirtana.

When Gadadhara Pandita, Bhagavan Acharya or Sarvabhauma invited the Lord, He accepted their invitation even if He had already been invited by others, and ate at their homes just as they wished (CC, Antya 8.88–89)[12]. And to Vallabha Bhatta the Lord named Gadadhara Pandita among the Vaishnavas born in Bengal who carry the holy name to the world:

“Acharyaratna, Acharyanidhi, Gadadhara Pandita, Jagadananda, Damodara, Shankara, Vakreshvara, Kashishvara, Mukunda, Vasudeva, Murari and many other Vaishnavas were born in the land of Bengal. All of them everywhere preach the glory of chanting the holy names of God and the enchanting beauty of love for Krishna. Thanks to them all I have understood the essence of unalloyed devotion to Krishna.” (CC, Antya 7.48–50)

The Test: Vallabha Bhatta

With this same Vallabha Bhatta is connected a story in which the nature of Gadadhara's love is seen with special clarity. Krishnadasa Kaviraja begins it thus:

“And that pure and deepest love which Gadadhara Pandita bore for Sri Chaitanya was like the submissive love that Queen Rukmini Devi felt for Krishna. Sometimes Sri Chaitanya wanted to arouse friendly anger in Gadadhara Pandita, but he never grew angry with the Lord, aware of His divine majesty. Sometimes Sri Chaitanya pretended to be angry with Gadadhara Pandita, but this only gave rise to great fear in him. As formerly Krishna sometimes teased Rukmini, but she took His words seriously, and her heart stood still with fear.” (CC, Antya 7.140–143)

Gadadhara was by nature simple and loving. Vallabha, proud of his learning, came to the Lord, and the Lord, to cure him of pride, withdrew from him and found fault with everything he said. Then Vallabha began to visit Gadadhara, showing him affection. Gadadhara came to love him, and this love became the occasion for a test: the Lord, as if displeased with their closeness, outwardly feigned anger and grew cool toward Gadadhara too. Gadadhara was afraid that the Lord would reject him.

Vallabha had formerly worshipped Bala-Gopala, Krishna as an infant; in the company of Gadadhara his heart changed:

“Vallabha Bhatta worshipped Krishna, trying to develop in himself the mood of parental love. So he performed his service, chanting the Bala-Gopala mantra. But in the company of Gadadhara Pandita he felt his heart change, and he began to worship Krishna in the form of a youth (Kishora-Gopala). Vallabha Bhatta wanted to accept Gadadhara Pandita as his spiritual master, receiving from him mantra and instructions in the worship of Krishna. But Gadadhara refused, saying: ‘Forgive me, but this is impossible. My master is Sri Gaurachandra, and I am wholly dependent on Him. Without His permission I will do nothing.’” (CC, Antya 7.144–147)

A few days later the Lord showered His mercy on Vallabha and, on the day of his invitation, sent Svarupa Damodara and others for Gadadhara. On the way Svarupa said: “The Lord was only testing you. Why did you not come and tell Him everything, instead of enduring it as if in fear?” Gadadhara replied: “The Lord knows everything about everyone; how could I be insolent to Him? I will bear whatever He says, and I trust that He will soon be merciful to me.” The duty of one who loves, he understood, is to accept from the beloved Lord any severity, for that too is affection. Arriving, he fell weeping at the Lord's feet:

“Sri Chaitanya embraced him with a smile and tenderly addressed him so that others too could hear His words: ‘I tried to make you angry, but you always kept your composure. You bore everything and did

not say even one angry word to Me in reply. However much I tried, I could not unsettle you. You have bought Me wholly and completely with your warmth of heart and simplicity.' It is impossible to describe all the greatness of Gadadhara Pandita's unalloyed love. Therefore Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu is also known as 'Gadadhara-prananatha' (the Lord of Gadadhara's heart). No one can describe Sri Chaitanya's mercy to Gadadhara Pandita either. Therefore Sri Chaitanya is sometimes known as 'Gadaira-Gauranga' (the Gauranga who belongs to Gadadhara)." (CC, Antya 7.156–160)

So by simplicity and patience Gadadhara "bought" the Lord. The next day he himself invited the Lord and His associates, and there Vallabha asked Mahaprabhu's permission to take initiation from Gadadhara; the Lord permitted it (CC, Antya 7.166–167). Thus Vallabha, who had formerly served the Bala-Gopala mantra, by Gadadhara's mercy received from the Pandita Gosvami initiation into the Kishora-Gopala mantra.

Cuttack: A Love That Knows No Vows

The time came when the Lord decided to go to Vrindavana. Ramananda Raya and Sarvabhauma long held Him back, but after Vijaya-dashami He set out after all — by way of Bengal; King Prataparudra saw to His journey, and beyond the river Chitrotpala Ramananda, Mardaraja and Hari-chandana went with Him. Gadadhara's vow of kshetra-sannyasa did not allow him to go further, but he could not bear the separation. The Lord reminded him of his vow and forbade him to come — and then an argument took place between them, which Krishnadasa Kaviraja relates thus:

"Gadadhara Pandita too made ready to go with the Lord, but Mahaprabhu forbade him, saying that he should not break his vow of kshetra-sannyasa. Gadadhara then said: 'Jagannatha Puri is always wherever You are, and let kshetra-sannyasa go to hell.' Sri Chaitanya said: 'Continue serving Gopinatha here.' Gadadhara answered: 'But beholding Your feet is a service millions of times greater.' Sri Chaitanya answered: 'If you abandon your service, it will be My fault. But I will be very pleased if you continue your service.' Gadadhara said: 'No, all this is my fault. And I will not go with You; I will set out on my own. I will go not because of You, but to see mother Shachi. Therefore the blame for abandoning the service and the vow will be wholly mine.'" (CC, Madhya 16.130–135)

The Lord went on northward, and Gadadhara followed, alone[13]. In Cuttack, about a hundred kilometres from Puri, the Lord called him to Him:

"Gadadhara's unconditional love for Sri Chaitanya is simply inconceivable. For the sake of Mahaprabhu's company Gadadhara abandoned his vow and the service of the Deity as something insignificant. Inwardly Sri Chaitanya was very pleased with Gadadhara's conduct, but, taking him by the hand, the Lord addressed him in loving anger: 'You have set off for distant lands, and in this way have abandoned your vow and the service of Gopinatha. Your desire to remain in My company is based on the wish for your own happiness. But that because of it you have transgressed two of your religious principles makes Me unhappy. If you want Me to be happy, then go back to Jagannatha Puri. If you say anything more in your own defence, you will bring misfortune upon Me.' Having said this, Mahaprabhu sailed away in a boat, and Gadadhara Pandita fell unconscious to the ground." (CC, Madhya 16.137–142)

Gadadhara bore the separation from the Lord harder than anyone[14], and his separation knew no bounds. The Lord entrusted him to Sarvabhauma — to console him and escort him back — and went on Himself. Sarvabhauma reminded Gadadhara how Krishna broke His own promise so as not to let Bhishma break his word: so too Mahaprabhu, parting from him against His own heart, was protecting his vow. And both, overcome by the grief of separation, returned to Puri (CC, Madhya 16.143–147). Such "rebellious" love — the readiness to abandon vows, service, everything for the Lord — is

understood only by the closest: love on the path of spontaneous devotion is not easy to grasp.

The Lord was then going to Gauda; in Ramakeli, where He bestowed His mercy on Rupa and Sanatana, the “Charitamrita” names Gadadhara too among His intimate associates; the Lord told them all to bless the two brothers (CC, Madhya 1.219–220)[15].

Gadadhara's Disciples and Branch

The branch of Gadadhara Pandita is one of the great branches of the Chaitanya tree. Among the first to take shelter of him were not disciples in the ordinary sense but the Lord's associates themselves: Narahari Sarakara had the good fortune to enter Gadadhara's company while Gadadhara served constantly at the Lord's side, and he became his follower; therefore Narahari's disciple Lochana Dasa writes that Gadadhara and Narahari are Mahaprabhu's dearest associates. A stanza on Narahari cited by one biography says just this: formerly Madhumati in Vrindavana, now in Shrikhanda, “following Gadadhara” — Narahari Sarakara. King Prataparudra too is called a branch of Gadadhara, and so is Vakreshvara — though Vakreshvara is also called a branch of Chaitanya Himself.

Bhugarbha was Gadadhara's disciple. When Lokanatha was taking leave of the Lord, weeping at His feet, Gadadhara was there with Bhugarbha; Bhugarbha, moved to the depths of his heart, wished to go with Lokanatha and asked permission of his guru. The Lord glanced approvingly at Gadadhara, and he gladly let his disciple go. So the two young men were the first of the Lord's devotees to go to Vrindavana. Together with Bhugarbha, Bhagavata Dasa, his fellow disciple and close friend, was a branch of Gadadhara:

“Bhugarbha Gosvami and Bhagavata Dasa came to Vrindavana and lived there all their lives.” (CC, Adi 12.82)

From Bhugarbha the branch continued through his disciples — Chaitanya Dasa, the pujari of Govinda, Mukundananda Chakravarti and “Premi” Krishnadasa.

Another disciple was Ananta Acharya:

“Ananta Acharya was a disciple of Sri Gadadhara Pandita. He was magnanimous, exalted and full of feelings of divine love for Krishna. Ananta Acharya possessed greatness and all virtues. And Haridasa Pandita was his beloved disciple.” (CC, Adi 8.59–60)

Ananta Acharya and Haridasa Pandita lived in Vrindavana and constantly heard the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” of Vrindavana Dasa; when Virachandra came to Vrindavana, they received him[16]. According to the “Anubhashya,” Ananta Acharya is the sakhi Sudevi (GGD 165), and in the line of the Ganga-mata-matha he is called “Vinoda-manjari”; Haridasa Pandita, also known as Raghu-gopala, is “Rasa-manjari.” Through Haridasa Pandita, Ganga-mata Gosvamini entered the line of the Gaura-shakti Gadadhara: Haridasa initiated her, a princess of Putiya; his disciple too was Lakshmipriya, Ganga-mata's maternal aunt.

Among the principal branches of Gadadhara the “Charitamrita” names Raghunatha Bhagavatacharya (Adi 12.80). He himself, in his “Sri Krishna-prema-tarangini,” calls himself a disciple of Gadadhara Pandita Gosvami: in the opening stanza he honors his guru Gadadhara — “the best of brahmanas, ever devoted to bhakti, dear to the devotees, in form a servant”[17]. In Vraja he is known as “Shveta-manjari.”

Achyutananda, the son of Advaita Acharya, is “the beloved disciple of Srimat Pandita Gosvami,” as the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” says (GGD 87); according to the “Shakha-nirnayamrita” of Yadunatha Dasa too he is a disciple and branch of Gadadhara, while Srila Bhaktisiddhanta in the “Anubhashya” calls him the first of the disciples of Advaita, Whose son he is. Achyutananda came to be regarded as the chief among Gadadhara's disciples, was present at the festival in Kheturi, and after the Lord's

disappearance and the departure of his guru returned to Shantipura and served the Lord's mission in obedience to his father. The “Shakha-nirnayamrita” itself (“The Nectar of Determining the Branches”) is a book about Gadadhara's disciples, written by his disciple Yadunatha Dasa; he also indicated that Chandrashekhara Acharya appeared in Shrihatta. This book glorifies Achyutananda with the stanza “mahā-rasāmṛtānandam…” and mentions (35) Uddhava Dasa — whom the “Charitamrita” too calls a branch of Gadadhara (Adi 12.84).

Gadadhara's beloved disciple was Paramananda Gosvami: together with Madhu Pandita he found the Deity of Gopinatha on the bank of the Yamuna, at Vamshivata. And Hridayananda, whom Gadadhara loved as his own life, he gave to Gauridasa Pandita. One morning Gauridasa came to him; Gadadhara seated his guest with honor and asked why he had come. “I need Hridayananda,” Gauridasa replied. And Gadadhara, painful as it was for him, placed Hridayananda's hand in the hand of Gauridasa; Gauridasa gave him diksha and later entrusted him with the service of Gaura-Nityananda.

Of Gadadhara's transcendental lineage Narottama Dasa Thakura sings: “…advaita-ācārya bala, gadādhara mora kula, narahari vilāsai mora” — “Advaita Acharya is my strength, Gadadhara is my lineage, Narahari is the companion of my pastimes.” Those born into this lineage acknowledge Gaurasundara as their only Lord, Nityananda as their wealth, Advaita as their strength, the feet of Radha-Govinda as their life, and Narahari as their companion in pastimes. When Narottama came to Puri, Tota-Gopinatha was served by Mamu Gosvami Thakura (the “Charitamrita” names him in Gadadhara's branch, Adi 12.81).

After the Lord's Disappearance

Mahaprabhu's manifest pastimes lasted forty-eight years. According to a tradition cited in the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” at their close the Lord entered the temple of Gadadhara Pandita's Gopinatha and did not come out again — He disappeared into this Deity[18].

After this Gadadhara remained on earth only eleven months. Narahari Chakravarti in the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (3.142 ff.) describes his grief: with closed eyes he repeated the name of Gaurasundara, his sighs burned like flame, and his motionless body lived only in order to await Srinivasa Acharya and bestow mercy on him.

Srinivasa came to Puri and the next morning went to Gadadhara's house. With tears he fell at his feet; Gadadhara lovingly raised and embraced him, and Srinivasa wept in separation from Gauranga; both sank into an ocean of divine feeling. Gadadhara and the other associates of the Lord whom Srinivasa saw lived only by the name, form, qualities and pastimes of Gaura. Srinivasa spent a day in his house, then went to the other associates, walked round the Kshetra, saw Gadadhara's Gopinatha, and for some time heard the “Bhagavatam” from the lips of the Pandita Gosvami — only this helped him hold on to life. At his order Srinivasa returned to Gauda; it was then too that Gadadhara sent him to Mayapur, to Vishnupriya.

Soon the news came that Gadadhara had departed. Srinivasa, having returned to Gauda and come to Shrikhanda, decided to go again to Nilachala and stay with Gadadhara, even against his order; but on the way he heard from pilgrims returning from Nilachala of his departure — and fell unconscious. In a dream Sri Gaura-Gadadhara appeared to him, and at Their command he resolved to go to Vrindavana by way of Navadvipa[19].

Gadadhara departed in Puri[20] on the new moon of the month of Jyeshtha in the year 1456 of the Shaka era (1534)[21]. On the same day, almost four centuries later, on 23 June 1914, Bhaktivinoda Thakura departed, “non-different from the Gaura-shakti Gadadhara.” In 1922 Srila Bhaktisiddhanta instituted at the Purushottama Matha (Bhakti-kuti in Puri) an annual festival in memory of Bhaktivinoda and

Gadadhara Pandita.

Places of Remembrance

Narottama Dasa Thakura, coming to Puri, on the advice of Gopinatha Acharya visited the samadhi of Haridasa Thakura, the Gambhira and the temple of Gadadhara Pandita's Gopinatha. He came to Gadadhara's house and cried aloud: “O life of Gauranga! O Gadadhara!” — and then received darshan of Tota-Gopinatha. He also approached that place of the Deity into which, according to tradition, the Lord had entered.

Since ancient times the Deity of Gadadhara has been worshipped daily to the left of Sri Gaurasundara. Witness to this are the ancient Deities of Sri Gaura-Gadadhara served by Dvija Vaninatha; they stand to this day in the village of Champahatta in Ritudvipa, one of the islands of Navadvipa. Whether this is the Vaninatha who was Gadadhara's younger brother is not said.

So too Lochana Dasa more than once describes Gadadhara to the left of Gaurasundara, Narahari to the right, and Raghunandana at His feet, drinking the nectar of His face. In the “Chaitanya-mangala” the Lord “with His left hand holds Gadadhara's hand” (Madhya-khanda, pt. 3, v. 25), and in Srivasa's house “Gadadhara and Narahari stand on either side” (pt. 6, v. 41). Lochana sings the glory of Sri Gaura-Gadadhara, and in the drama at Chandrashekhara's house Srivasa, in the mood of Narada, glorifies Gadadhara: “You are the first of prakritis, you are Radha, Krishna's shakti” (pt. 11, v. 101). In Saptagrama, beside the six-armed form of Mahaprabhu installed by Uddharana Datta, Nityananda stands on the right and Gadadhara on the left; and in the royal palace in Puri, among many images, the Deities of Gaura-Nityananda and Gaura-Gadadhara are worshipped too.

The Gaudiya Maths too preserve the memory of Gaura-Gadadhara. Bhaktivinoda Thakura established the service of Gaura-Gadadhara, seeing in Them Radha-Madhava; Srila Bhaktisiddhanta restored the service of Gaura-Gadadhara in Champahatta and founded there the Gaura-Gadadhara Math, and in Baliati (Dhaka) the Gadai-Gauranga Math. At Prabhupada's wish Bhakti Vilasa Tirtha Maharaja built a temple of Gadadhara beside the Advaita-bhavana in Srivasa-angana, and Bhakti Pramoda Puri Maharaja in 1989 founded in Ishodyan the Sri Gopinath Gaudiya Math for the service of Sri Sri Gaura-Gadadhara.

Radha in Gaura-lila

Who Gadadhara was in Krishna-lila is told by the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” of Kavi Karnapura:

“Sri Radha, love personified, formerly the Queen of Vrindavana, is Sri Gadadhara, dear to Gaura, called the Pandita. As Sri Svarupa determined, he is the Lakshmi of Vraja: ‘The Lakshmi who was once the beloved of Shyamasundara in Vrindavana is now the Lakshmi of Gaura's love, Sri Gadadhara Pandita.’ Since Lalita follows Radha, being ‘Anuradhika,’ she too entered into him, as is said in the ‘Gaura-chandrodaya.’” (GGD 147–150)

She who in Krishna-lila was the daughter of Vrishabhanu, Srimati Radharani, became Gadadhara in Gaura-lila; this is confirmed by the notes of Svarupa Damodara and the songs of Vasudeva Ghosha. That is why Pundarika, Vrishabhanu, is his guru and the Lord's “father” in the mood of Radha; that is why the Lord said that in Vaikuntha Gadadhara is His consort, and in Navadvipa he and Gaura are what Radha and Krishna are in Vrindavana. One biography calls Gadadhara the embodiment of hladini, the Lord's pleasure energy. Kavi Karnapura in the “Gaura-ganoddesha” shows the distinction between the two Gadadharas: Gadadhara Pandita is the form of Sri Radhika (GGD 153), the svarupa of the daughter of Vrishabhanu, while Gadadhara Dasa is Chandrakanti, “a manifestation of Radha's glory” (GGD 154), the radiance of Her body; so too teaches Srila Bhaktisiddhanta: Gadadhara Pandita is Radha Herself, Gadadhara Dasa Her bodily effulgence.

All this is a transcendental mystery, and it must be understood as Bhaktisiddhanta teaches. Gaura is Krishna Himself, Who has taken the mood and radiance of Radha, and Gadadhara is Radha serving Him in the form of a devotee-brahmana. Their intimacy is not the worldly attachment of two people but the eternal play of the Lord with His own internal energy; even Gadadhara's feminine attire in the drama at Chandrashekhara's house is a revelation of this energy, not worldly play-acting[22].

Two Gadadharas

In the year 1340 of the Bengali era (1933–1934) a pamphlet appeared, the “Dasa Gadadhara-tattva.” Its author, posing as an admirer of Gadadhara Dasa, in a sectarian spirit set Gadadhara Pandita against him. Supposedly the Pandita, having studied nyaya, at first did not wish to submit to Dasa Gadadhara, the expounder of the “Bhagavatam”; and, realizing that he was being deprived of the taste of Gauranga's pastimes, in submission to Advaita Acharya — a manifestation of Gopeshvara-Shiva — became a disciple of Pundarika Vidyanidhi, a “bilva tree” in Advaita's sub-branch, and only then took shelter of the mood of Dasa Gadadhara; and therefore those who follow Pandita Gadadhara would do better to leave him and follow the Dasa. Such a view is the height of pashanditva, godlessness.

The two Gadadharas must not be separated and set against each other: both are associates of Gaura, His own people, eternal associates both in Gaura-lila and in Vraja-lila. To honor one and reject the other is exactly what the “Charitamrita” calls the logic of half a hen:

“If you believe in one and are disrespectful to the other, your logic is in every way like accepting only one half of a hen (the one that lays eggs).” (CC, Adi 5.176)

Such logic the gurus have not told us to accept; and the distinction spoken of by Kavi Karnapura and Bhaktisiddhanta (Radha Herself and Her radiance) is no ground for rivalry, but different services within one lila.

Significance

The life of Gadadhara Pandita — from his childhood games with Nimai to the eleven months of separation in Yameshvara-tota — was wholly given to Gaura. He is His shakti, Radha serving Him; that is why the Lord is “the life of Gadadhara,” and whoever wishes to serve Radha-Govinda in madhura-rasa takes shelter of him. His life teaches humility before guru and Vaishnavas (Pundarika, the mantra in Puri), the simplicity and patience by which the Lord is “bought” (Vallabha Bhatta), and a love ready to abandon both vow and service only to be with the Lord — and obedience when the Lord orders him to return (Cuttack). And his “Bhagavata,” which resounded by Narendra lake, reminds us that the “Bhagavata” must be heard from a bhagavata.

His glory is also sung in the “Sri Gadadhara-pandita-gosvami-dashaka,” verses attributed to Rupa Gosvami; their copy from a manuscript of the Madras Government Oriental Library was printed in the “Gaudiya.”

Bhaktivinoda Thakura, who departed on the day of his departure, left an instruction in which Gaura and Gadadhara are one:

“Remember the pastimes of Gaura-Gadadhara, become a servant of Gaura-Gadadhara, hear the wondrous narrations of Gaura-Gadadhara, and worship Gaura — the moon of the groves of Godruma” (“smara gaura-gadādhara keli-kalām…”).

1. According to the “Prema-vilasa” (vilasa 22), Gadadhara was born in Navadvipa.

2. According to some accounts, Gadadhara was born in 1486, that is, in the same year as the Lord; according to others, he was a year younger than Gaurahari.

3. According to one biography, Ishvara Puri stayed with Gopinatha Acharya for a month; according to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Adi 11.96, “māsa-kata”), for several months.

4. According to one biography, at the sight of the Lord Gadadhara lost consciousness, overcome by sattvika-bhavas; according to another, he lowered his head and wept loudly and long, and the Lord asked who was weeping there. The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” has both: first he lost consciousness (Madhya 1.88), and then, when the Lord asked about him, he wept with lowered head (1.97).

5. According to one biography, this was in the procession to the Kazi itself, and Advaita rushed about holding on to Nityananda and Gadadhara; according to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Madhya 23.17–30), it was at a kirtana in Srivasa's house, before the procession, and it was Nityananda and Gadadhara who held hands.

6. One biography renders the Lord's words about Gadadhara more mildly — “he is of My Vaikuntha family”; the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Madhya 18.116) says plainly: “In Vaikuntha Gadadhara is My wife.” The same passage (18.115) explains that Gadadhara is a manifestation of Krishna's internal energy: these are not worldly ties but the eternal service of the shakti to her Lord.

7. Elsewhere one biography tells of the meeting differently: Gadadhara, one of the Lord's closest associates, himself wished to see the one for whom the Lord so longed, and asked Mukunda to take him. Vidyanidhi eagerly asked who this associate was, whose form shone with devotion to Vishnu; Gadadhara, however, doubted whether such a dandy, on a costly bed, amid perfumes and servants, could be a devotee. At a verse of the “Bhagavatam” (3.2.23) on Krishna's supreme mercy Vidyanidhi, in streams of tears, fell from his bed, smashed the costly utensils with his feet and loudly lamented that he had not become a vessel of the mercy of such a Lord; the astonished Gadadhara, to atone for his doubt, wished, if he would consent, to receive diksha from him, and Mahaprabhu, learning of it, was overjoyed.

8. According to one biography, Mukunda introduced Gadadhara only after Pundarika had come to himself from his ecstasy.

9. How many verses were sung is told differently: one verse of the “Bhagavatam” (3.2.23, about Putana); two verses (3.2.23 and 10.6.35); a Bengali couplet about Putana together with two verses of the “Bhagavatam.” One biography in different places speaks now of one verse, now of two.

10. According to one account, it was Mahaprabhu Himself who advised Gadadhara to atone for the offense by taking initiation from Pundarika; according to others, Gadadhara decided this himself.

11. The Lord's companions on the way from Shantipura to Puri are named differently: according to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” — Nityananda, Gadadhara Pandita, Mukunda, Govinda, Brahmananda (and Jagadananda); according to the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” — Nityananda, Jagadananda, Damodara and Mukunda, without Gadadhara. One biography names “these four”: Nityananda, Jagadananda, Gadadhara Pandita and Mukunda Datta.

12. According to one biography, He would then eat as much as was served.

13. One biography writes that the Lord was heading for Vrindavana by the route through Jharikhanda; but according to the “Charitamrita” (Madhya 16) this was the route to Gauda, through Bengal, and the Lord took the forest route through Jharikhanda later (Madhya 17).

14. According to one biography, he lost consciousness even before the Lord boarded the boat; according to the “Charitamrita” (Madhya 16.142), when the Lord had already sailed away.

15. According to the “Charitamrita” (Madhya 16.147), Gadadhara returned from Cuttack to Puri with Sarvabhauma; in the list of the Lord's companions at Ramakeli (Madhya 1.219) there stands simply the name “Gadadhara.”

16. According to some accounts, Ananta Acharya and Haridasa Pandita were pujaris of Madana-mohana; according to others, Virachandra was received in Vrindavana by Ananta Acharya, Haridasa Pandita and Krishnadasa Brahmachari — a disciple of Gadadhara Pandita and servant of Madana-Gopala. According to the “Charitamrita” (Adi 8.54), Haridasa Pandita was the manager of Govinda's temple.

17. According to the “Prema-vilasa,” Bhagavatacharya (formerly Bada Shyamadasa) was a disciple of Advaita Acharya.

18. Traditions about the Lord's disappearance differ; this is one of them.

19. How Srinivasa learned of his departure is told differently: according to one biography, having already taken leave and set out on the road to Bengal, he heard that Gadadhara had disappeared, and that same night Gadadhara appeared to him in a dream and consoled him; according to the “Prema-vilasa” (4), he learned of it in Yajpur, on the way to Puri.

20. One biography, speaking of Gadadhara Dasa, says that “after the disappearance of Gadadhara Pandita Gosvami” a samadhi was erected for him in Eriyadaha; from the context the reference is to Gadadhara Dasa, whose shripata is in Eriyadaha, while Gadadhara Pandita departed in Puri.

21. The year 1456 of the Shaka era, in the month of Jyeshtha, corresponds to 1534; one biography gives 1535. The same biography names as the day of his departure now the new moon of Jyeshtha, now the new moon of Ashadha.

22. The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Madhya 18.115) itself explains: “In truth, he is a manifestation of Krishna's internal energy.” Gaura-lila is the Lord's play with His own energy, inaccessible to worldly interpretation.